

Walking to Avoid the Wallows

The sun was burning hot. Sand whipped into Rej as the wind buffeted him. Despite the kerchief wrapped around his face, yellow grains still managed to slip down his neck, under his collar.

Dust was on his tongue, in his boots, the pack on his back chafed at his shoulders. This was a tough walk, the toughest he had ever tried. And now it was becoming dangerous.

He double-checked his map, yes, he was at the next watering hole.

Rej toed the brown, dried up earth in front of him. The last one had been empty too. The one before that as well.

Three watering holes, back-to-back-to-back, dried to the brim in the harsh Australian desert.

A sharp sting of fear made his fingers tremble. It was a familiar feeling.

The issue, as it always was, was that it went hand in hand with the gripping excitement.

Rej placed down his bag to take stock. He had five litres left, and looking at the map, the next hole was five kms away, half a day's trek.

If that one was depleted too ...

Rej had already been rationing, his lips were dry, the thirst scratching his throat. Continuing forward would be a huge risk.

And he was only going deeper into the desert. He could bail out, the country road was about a day and a half away, he could hitchhike back to safety.

But Rej wanted, no, needed to finish this walk. He had to succeed after so much failure. Hiking in open country was his favourite past-time, not only was it a challenge, a testament to his body, but the untamed environment was revitalising. It focused him, allowed him to breathe, enabled him to ... forget.

Forget the flashing lights, the feel of the green felt, the thrill of putting it all on the line.

The ecstasy of winning.

The shame of watching it all disappear. And having to deal with the consequences, facing the people he loved, the *burning* ...

Rej bit his lip to get back to the topic on hand.

This wasn't a popular trail but someone had to upkeep it.

Three watering-holes in a row could only be absurdly bad luck. There was no chance that the next hole would also be dried up.

Right?

It was a gamble. It wasn't Rej's worst.

This time would be different. He wouldn't be a failure, not out here in his element. Slipping on his bag, Rej moved further into the desert, sand and dust puffing around his shoes with his every step.

"Are you alright?"

"Pardon?"

"I asked if you're alright? You barely ate, you seem jumpy ... I know you don't ever want to talk about work but maybe you should ..."

"Everything's fine."

"Ok. Well if you need something to distract you, I think Isaac has something he wants to show you in his room ..."

Rej shook his head to disperse the memories. He checked his watch, it was four pm, time to begin moving.

He couldn't walk during the day due to the exorbitant heat. Before leaving he checked his water levels, despite extreme rationing, there wasn't much left. The thirst was constant, a relentless ache that cut into his throat.

He tried to ignore the fact that his last piss had been murky brown. The next watering hole wasn't far, and it would be filled to the brim, liquid gold swirling around a mud-caked hole.

Rej packed down his tent and rose to his feet. His vision blurred, body swaying forward until he checked himself. He tried to grab his bottle, it took a few seconds for his hand to stop shaking.

The water tasted rusty and was almost boiling; it was bliss as it ran down his throat.

Rej began walking, hoping that the monotonous pace would make him feel better. Out here, where there was nothing but the heat, sun and noise of the wind, where he was all by himself, was what Rej needed.

He felt himself close his eyes. Until he snapped them back open. He thought he saw something out in the distance. A figure of some sort.

Was it another person? Maybe they could share some water with him.

He stared out at the figure. There was something off about it, similar to the hazy shimmer of a mirage but just a little bit different, something that Rej couldn't put his finger on. He squinted and a second smaller person stood next to the original, cuddling its leg. Rej felt his breath quicken

as he saw grey smoke coil above both of them, thickets of the stuff as snap of a gas clicker began to echo in his ear.

No...

Rej turned and ran the other way, feet sliding on the sand in a knee jerk reaction, a yell escaping from his dry throat. Fear, guilt, panic start gripping him.

Wait.

What was he doing? They couldn't be here. It still took him a second to muster the courage to look back.

The figures were gone. The landscape was just orange arid desert, empty par the boiling sun.

Rej took the time to breath, to submerge the memories of them, they were gone, he was here, now, alone.

They couldn't be here with him. Not after what he ...

"Watering hole, I need the watering hole" Rej hissed to distract himself, opening his map and setting off.

There was nothing but the heat, the sun and noise of the wind. Within no time at all, Rej found himself at his destination.

He cried out with joy. Bright sunlight reflected off of the pool. Rej jumped into the water and sunk his face into the murk, lapping up the cool liquid.

It burnt.

Rej began coughing, choking, as hot, dry grains of sand scalded his throat. He wheezed and stuck two fingers down his oesophagus, pressing as hard as he could until he felt his chest buck, throwing up sick onto the ground.

Rej sat down in a daze, head reeling, barely registering the stringy, green mucus sticking to his index and middle finger. Sweat covered his forehead. It was more water he couldn't afford to lose.

When he finally seemed to get control of himself, he looked down at the watering hole.

It was just another brown, cracked, dried up piece of the land.

Rej covered his face in his hands.

"Not again. Please not again."

"You never learn..."

Rej looked up at the voice and his jaw dropped.

In the distance, standing on the sand, was the larger figure from before.

Yet now it was on fire.

The person blazed fiercely, red embers dropping to the ground like magma, a human body covered in a fiery conflagration.

It began moving towards him, each step leaving black scorch marks in the sand.

Shock and horror slammed into Rej. But it wasn't what made tears stream down his cheeks, wasn't what made his throat clog up in emotion.

That was the guilt. The overpowering guilt he was striving to forget.

Rej screamed and ran the opposite direction, the burning figure following him with a steady easy pace.

"There was a man over during the day."

"Are you alright?"

"No. You told me you had stopped hitting the tables Rej. You promised me!"

"Well I didn't see you complaining when I bought the house, the fancy car, spoiled you with jewels and dresses."

"You said you had gotten the job ..."

"Well I hadn't. I fucking hadn't. I did my duty for my family. For you!"

"And what now? Because that man went into vivid detail what would happen if you didn't pay them what was owed."

"Just a hiccup. Alright. I'll get my edge back."

"Rej. He grabbed Isaac's arm. He threatened us. This isn't a game you can just lose."

Rej stumbled on the sand. The world was spinning, the air above the ground shimmering in an impenetrable haze. He didn't know where he was, didn't know where he was going. The map was gone. Along with his bag, his bottles, he'd shed everything apart from his clothes, in his mad dash to be away from the figure.

Or figures.

There were two of them, each getting closer and closer. They weren't just following him, sometimes they teleported, appearing in different directions. One was smaller than the other, and burned with fury, the blaze engulfing it's tiny form.

Despite the desert Rej could feel their heat. It burned into him, making him howl in his mad attempts to escape. His body was caked with sweat and sand, dust crusting his fingernails.

His knees felt like they would give out, yet he pressed on. Trying to get away.

He never would.

Eventually, he fell to the ground, yet still he crawled, the sand burning into his skin with every movement.

When the figures reached his trembling body, they crouched down onto their knees.

The fire scorched hotter as their burning arms wrapped around Rej in a hug.

Rej screamed and screamed as the heat scorched into him, melting his flesh.

"We forgive you."

Why did it matter when he could never forgive himself?